```
exec(action)
if DEV_SERVER:
    print('Importing settings: s' % import_file)

action = ('from RiffMates.local_settings.secrets.'
    '%s import *' % import_file)
exec(action)
if DEV_SERVER:
    print('Importing secrets: %s' % import_file)
```

Execute the import command.

If this is the development server, print some info about the import.

Repeat the process but for the corresponding secrets file.

Another alternative combines elements of these two options. The third-party library django-environ reads from a .env file in you project directory and populates the variables within, allowing you to access them. You can also use an environment variable to specify a different name for .env, meaning an operating system environment variable can cause `.dev_env` to be loaded in one place and `.prod_env` in another.

B.4.2 Configuring email

In chapter 6, you were introduced to the idea of an email backend. Django comes with several ways of "sending" email, including outputting what would normally be sent to the development server's console. If your Django project uses email, you're going to want to connect to an actual email server.

Email can be a little tricky. Email gets sent using the *Simple Mail Transfer Protocol* (SMTP). For small volumes, your hosting provider may include an SMTP server. Staying out of your user's spam folder can be a challenge, and properly configuring a server so that it isn't suspected of spewing junk mail is important.

For larger volumes of email, you want a service provider. Companies such as Mailgun, SendGrid, and Mailchimp allow you to send mail through their systems and work with the common email clients, such as Gmail and Outlook, to help ensure you stay out of the spam folder.

Whichever service provider you choose, you need to change the configuration in settings.py to point at their system. A sample configuration is as follows:

```
# RiffMates/RiffMates/settings.py
...
EMAIL_BACKEND = \
    'django.core.mail.backends.smtp.EmailBackend'
EMAIL_USE_TLS = True
EMAIL_HOST = 'smtp.example.com'
EMAIL_PORT = 587
EMAIL_HOST_USER = 'username'
EMAIL_HOST_PASSWORD = 'password'
```

Email backend for connecting to an SMTP server

Use an encrypted connection.

Host of the SMTP service

Network port of the SMTP service

Username and password of your account on the SMTP server

Of course, storing a password in clear text or in a file in your code repository is not a recommended practice. The `EMAIL_HOST_PASSWORD` value should be set using an environment variable or imported from a separate file, as discussed in the previous section.